DARKHAN MENTOR | RESEARCH REPORT SERIES

How to Write an Islamic Research Paper

A Research Report

A practical guide for students and beginning researchers: choosing a topic, working with the Qur'an and the Sunnah, using classical and modern sources, structuring an argument, citing sources correctly, and presenting differences of opinion with respect and balance.

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Chapter : Abstract

Islamic research is the disciplined study of revelation, tradition, history, law, theology, ethics and Muslim civilisation, carried out with honesty, care and reverence. This report explains, step by step, how a student can produce an original Islamic research paper: from choosing a worthwhile question, through reading the primary sources in the Qur'an and the Sunnah, to consulting tafsir, hadith collections, fiqh and modern scholarship, and finally to writing a clear, well-structured and properly referenced paper. It covers research methods suited to Islamic studies, including textual analysis, comparative fiqh, historical method and, where appropriate, survey and fieldwork. It gives practical rules for citing Qur'anic verses, hadith and scholarly opinions, guidance on discussing differences of opinion without partisanship, and the ethical standards that Islamic scholarship itself demands: sincerity of intention, accuracy, fairness to opposing views, and respect for sacred texts and for the scholars of the past. A complete worked example — a full outline and a model introduction on the concept of sabr (patience) in the Qur'an — shows how the guidance works in practice. The report closes with the most common mistakes beginners make and a final checklist that can be used before any paper is submitted.

The report is written for undergraduate and early postgraduate students, for teachers supervising student research, and for any reader who wishes to study Islam seriously and write about it responsibly. No prior training in research methods is assumed. Every recommendation is practical: it can be applied to the very next paper the reader writes, whether that paper is a short class assignment or a longer dissertation chapter.

Key words: Islamic research; research methodology; Qur'an; Sunnah; hadith; tafsir; fiqh; citation; academic honesty; sabr.

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How to use this report: Chapters 1 to 4 explain what Islamic research is and what sources and methods it uses. Chapters 5 to 7 are the practical core — topic, structure and citation. Chapters 8 and 9 deal with the character of the researcher. Chapter 10 puts everything together in one worked example, and Chapter 11 is the checklist to use before submission.

Chapter 1: Introduction — What Islamic Research Is and Its Aims

Research in Islamic studies is the systematic, honest search for understanding of Islam: its scripture, its Prophet's example, its law, its theology, its history and its civilisation. It is not the collection of quotations to support an opinion already formed, and it is not the repetition of what others have said. It is a disciplined effort to find out what the sources actually say, how scholars have understood them, where they agree and where they differ, and what that understanding means for life today.

The first revealed word of the Qur'an, in the opening verses of Surah al-'Alaq (96), is a command to read. That command has shaped fourteen centuries of Muslim scholarship. From the earliest collections of hadith to the great works of tafsir, fiqh, history, philosophy and science, Muslim scholars treated learning as an act of worship and as a trust. A modern research paper continues that tradition in a new form: it asks a question, examines evidence, weighs arguments and presents a conclusion that others can check.

1.1 What counts as Islamic research?

Islamic research covers a wide field. A paper may study a Qur'anic theme, such as justice, mercy or patience; it may examine a hadith and its chain of transmission; it may compare the rulings of the schools of law on a single question; it may trace the history of an institution, a city or a movement; or it may study how Muslims live their faith today. What makes such work research, rather than preaching or general reading, is method: a clear question, identified sources, a stated way of handling them, and conclusions that follow from the evidence.

- It begins with a question, not an answer. The researcher genuinely wants to find out something.
- It uses primary sources wherever possible, and distinguishes them from later commentary.
- It reports evidence fairly, including evidence that points against the researcher's first view.
- It can be checked: every claim that needs a source has one, and the reader can follow the references.
- It adds something, however small: a clearer reading, a new comparison, a better-organised survey of views, or a careful application to a new situation.

1.2 The aims of Islamic research

The aims are both scholarly and personal. Scholarly aims include understanding the texts accurately, preserving and transmitting knowledge, resolving apparent contradictions, and answering new questions raised by new circumstances. Personal

aims include sincerity of intention, humility before the sources, and the desire to benefit others. Classical scholars often reminded their students that knowledge is sought for the sake of God and for the benefit of people, not for fame, argument or worldly gain. A researcher who keeps that intention in view will write more carefully and more fairly.

A good paper also serves its readers. It should help a reader understand a topic they did not understand before, give them reliable references to follow up, and show them how a conclusion was reached rather than asking them to accept it on trust. Clarity is therefore not a luxury; it is part of the researcher's duty to the reader.

1.3 Who this report is for

This report is written for students writing their first research paper in Islamic studies, for teachers who supervise such work, and for independent readers who wish to study Islam seriously. It assumes no prior training in research methods. Technical terms are explained when they first appear, and every rule is illustrated with an example. A reader who works through the chapters in order will finish with a complete method; a reader in a hurry can use Chapter 5 for the topic, Chapter 6 for the structure, Chapter 7 for citation, and Chapter 11 as the final check.

Chapter 2: The Foundations: The Qur'an and the Sunnah as Primary Sources

Every Islamic research paper rests, directly or indirectly, on two primary sources: the Qur'an, the revealed word of God, and the Sunnah, the example of the Prophet Muhammad (peace be upon him) as preserved in authentic hadith. A researcher must understand the nature of each source, how to read it responsibly, and how the two relate to each other.

2.1 The Qur'an

The Qur'an is the central text of Islam, revealed over twenty-three years and preserved in the Arabic language. For research purposes, three points matter most. First, the Qur'an must be studied in Arabic wherever the argument depends on wording; translations are aids to understanding, not substitutes for the original text, and different translations may render the same verse differently. Second, verses must be read in context: the surrounding verses, the surah as a whole, the circumstances of revelation where reliably reported, and the Qur'an's own cross-references all shape meaning. A single verse lifted from its context can easily be misread. Third, the Qur'an interprets itself in important ways: themes recur, general statements are qualified elsewhere, and one passage often clarifies another.

When you use a Qur'anic verse in a paper, give the surah name and number and the verse number, and check the reference in a reliable printed text or a trusted digital

edition. Quote only as much as your argument needs, and never alter the wording. If you paraphrase a verse, say clearly that it is a paraphrase. Where scholars differ over a verse's meaning, report the main interpretations rather than presenting one as the only possible reading.

2.2 The Sunnah and hadith

The Sunnah is the Prophet's teaching, practice and approved example, and hadith are the reports that transmit it. Each hadith has two parts: the chain of transmission (isnad) and the text (matn). Classical scholars developed a rigorous science of hadith criticism, examining the reliability, memory and continuity of narrators, and comparing texts for consistency. As a result, hadith are classified by degrees of authenticity, and a researcher must know which classification applies to the reports they use.

For a student paper, the practical rules are simple. Use hadith from recognised collections — above all the two Sahih collections and the other well-known Sunan works — and give the collection, book and number so the reader can verify the report. Prefer reports whose authenticity is well established, and say so when a report is disputed or weak. Never quote a saying without checking its source; sayings circulate widely on the internet and in popular books without any reliable chain. If a hadith is central to your argument, mention what the classical commentators said about it, not only the bare text.

2.3 How the two sources work together

The Qur'an and the Sunnah are complementary. The Qur'an gives the foundational commands and principles; the Sunnah shows how they were lived and applied, and clarifies details the Qur'an states in general terms — for example, the practical form of prayer and the details of pilgrimage. A paper that uses one source while ignoring the other will usually be incomplete. At the same time, the researcher must keep the hierarchy clear: a well-established Qur'anic text is not set aside by a weak or isolated report, and a sound hadith is not dismissed merely because it is inconvenient. The classical principle was to bring the sources together, weigh them by their strength, and follow the strongest evidence with humility.

Chapter 3: Secondary Sources: Tafsir, Hadith Collections, Fiqh and Scholarly Works

Primary sources are the foundation, but no researcher reads them alone. Fourteen centuries of scholarship stand between the modern reader and the age of revelation, and that scholarship is itself a source of guidance. Secondary sources explain the primary texts, record how they have been understood, and show where scholars agreed and disagreed. A good paper uses them critically: it learns from them without

surrendering judgement to them.

3.1 Tafsir (Qur'anic exegesis)

Tafsir literature explains the Qur'an verse by verse. The earliest tafsir works transmit the explanations of the Companions and the early generations; later works add linguistic analysis, legal derivation, theological discussion and attention to the coherence of each surah. When researching a Qur'anic theme, consult more than one tafsir, and consult works from more than one period and approach. Note where commentators agree — that agreement is itself evidence — and where they differ, and why. A difference may come from a different reading of an Arabic word, from a different report about the circumstances of revelation, or from a different legal or theological framework. Naming the reason for a difference is more useful than merely listing the differing views.

3.2 Hadith collections and commentaries

The great hadith collections organise reports by topic or by narrator, and the classical commentaries on them explain difficult words, discuss the chains of transmission, reconcile apparently conflicting reports, and draw out legal and ethical implications. When you cite a hadith, the commentary is often where the real research value lies: it tells you whether scholars considered the report authentic, how they understood its wording, and whether its ruling was general or specific to a situation. Modern encyclopaedias and databases of hadith are useful for finding reports, but they do not replace the commentaries, and their authenticity gradings should be checked against recognised scholarly judgements.

3.3 Fiqh and the schools of law

Fiqh is the science of deriving practical rulings from the sources, and the schools of law (madhahib) are its great organised traditions. Each school has its own methodology for weighing Qur'an, Sunnah, consensus and analogy, and its own corpus of legal texts. A researcher studying a legal question should first establish what each school says, then examine the evidence each school relies on, and only then offer an assessment. Quoting a single school's conclusion without its evidence, or presenting one school's view as the view of Islam as a whole, is one of the commonest errors in student work. The comparative study of fiqh — fiqh al-muqaran — is a valuable research method precisely because it forces the researcher to compare evidence, not merely conclusions.

3.4 Modern scholarship and other disciplines

Modern academic writing on Islam — in English, Arabic, Urdu and other languages — includes historical studies, linguistic research, and work on Muslim societies today. It should be used alongside the classical sources, not instead of them. Judge modern works by the same standards as classical ones: the quality of their sources, the

fairness of their argument, and the transparency of their method. Works from other disciplines — history, sociology, economics, education — can also enrich an Islamic research paper, especially where the topic touches on contemporary life. When borrowing a concept from another discipline, define it clearly and show how it applies to the Islamic material, rather than assuming the fit.

Chapter 4: Research Methods in Islamic Studies

Method is the bridge between a question and an answer. Islamic studies uses several established methods, and a good paper names its method and uses it consistently. The choice of method follows from the question: a question about the meaning of a verse calls for textual analysis; a question about differing legal rulings calls for comparative fiqh; a question about how a practice developed calls for historical method; a question about how Muslims understand a teaching today may call for fieldwork. Many papers combine two methods, but they should do so deliberately, with each method used where it fits.

4.1 Textual analysis

Textual analysis is the close, careful reading of a text: its words, grammar, structure and context. In Qur'anic study it means attending to the Arabic wording, the place of a verse in its surah, the relationship between verses, and the range of meanings a word can carry. In hadith study it means reading the text alongside its chain, its variant wordings, and the commentaries. Good textual analysis is slow work. It quotes the text accurately, considers alternative readings, and distinguishes what the text says from what the reader wishes it said. A paper built on textual analysis should show the reader the key passages, explain the difficult words, and build its argument step by step from the text outward.

4.2 Comparative fiqh

Comparative fiqh compares the rulings and the reasoning of the legal schools on a single question. Its steps are: state the question precisely; collect the ruling of each school from its authoritative texts; identify the evidence each school cites; compare the strength of that evidence and the principles used to weigh it; and conclude with a reasoned preference, or with an honest statement that the evidence is balanced. The value of this method is that it disciplines the researcher: a preference must be argued from evidence, not asserted from loyalty to a school or a teacher. Even where the researcher finally follows one view, the paper should present the other views accurately enough that their supporters would recognise them.

4.3 Historical method

Historical method traces how a teaching, institution or movement developed over time. It uses chronicles, biographical dictionaries, legal texts, letters and material evidence, and it asks when a practice began, how it changed, and why. The historian of Islam must be careful with sources: early reports may be fragmentary, later works may project later debates backwards, and every source has a perspective. The remedy is comparison — checking one source against others, preferring contemporary evidence where it exists, and distinguishing firmly between what is established, what is probable and what is merely possible. A historical paper should give dates, name its sources, and avoid filling gaps in the evidence with imagination.

4.4 Survey and fieldwork, where appropriate

Some questions cannot be answered from books alone. How do teachers in a particular city teach a subject? What do young Muslims understand by a given concept? How is a charitable practice organised in practice? Such questions call for surveys, interviews or observation. Fieldwork in Islamic studies must meet the same ethical standards as fieldwork anywhere: participants give informed consent, their privacy is protected, questions are neutral rather than leading, and results are reported honestly, including results that surprise the researcher. A small, carefully designed survey with clear limitations is worth more than a large, careless one. Fieldwork should also be combined with textual study: what people do and what the texts teach are two different questions, and confusing them is a serious error.

4.5 Choosing and combining methods

A paper does not need every method. It needs the right method for its question, applied thoroughly. State the method in the methodology section, explain why it fits the question, and note its limits. If you combine methods — for example, textual analysis of the sources with a small survey of contemporary understanding — explain how the two parts relate and which question each part answers. A method section that honestly admits limits strengthens a paper; one that claims more than the method can deliver weakens it.

Worked example — matching method to question: Question: 'What does the Qur'an say about patience?' Method: textual analysis of the relevant verses, grouped by theme. Question: 'How do the schools of law differ on a particular ruling?' Method: comparative fiqh. Question: 'How did the institution of the waqf develop in one region?' Method: historical method. Question: 'What do students in my city understand by sabr?' Method: a short survey, combined with textual study of the Qur'anic teaching.

Chapter 5: Choosing a Topic and Formulating a Research Question

The most important decision in any research paper is the topic, and the most important step after choosing it is turning it into a precise research question. A broad topic — 'Islam and society', 'the Qur'an', 'Islamic law' — cannot be covered in one paper. A research question narrows it to something that can actually be answered: a specific text, a specific comparison, a specific period, a specific place.

5.1 Finding a good topic

A good topic has four qualities. First, it interests you enough to sustain weeks of work; a topic chosen only because it sounds impressive will be abandoned at the first difficulty. Second, sources exist and are accessible to you, in languages you can read or with reliable translations you can check. Third, it is narrow enough to be finished in the time and length available — a class paper of a few thousand words can answer one small question well, but cannot survey a whole field. Fourth, it matters: it fills a gap, corrects a misunderstanding, compares views that have not been compared, or applies an established teaching to a new situation.

Begin by reading broadly around a general area that interests you, noting questions that arise as you read. Talk to a teacher or supervisor early: an experienced reader can tell in minutes whether a topic is too broad, whether the sources exist, and whether the question has already been answered. Keep a notebook of candidate topics, and for each one write a single sentence saying what you want to find out. If you cannot write that sentence, the topic is not yet ready.

5.2 From topic to research question

A research question is a single, clear, answerable question. It should name the subject, the angle and, where relevant, the scope. Compare a weak topic statement with a strong question: 'Islamic finance' is a topic, not a question; 'How do contemporary scholars justify the permissibility of diminishing musharakah for home purchase, and what objections have been raised?' is a question that can be researched. The question should be open — capable of more than one answer — but focused enough that the evidence can settle it, or at least narrow it.

- Too broad: 'What does Islam say about women?' Better: 'How do classical and modern commentators interpret the Qur'anic verses on consultation (shura) within the family?'
- Too vague: 'Hadith are important.' Better: 'How is the hadith on intentions used as a legal principle in the works of two classical jurists?'
- Unanswerable: 'What is the true meaning of life?' Better: 'How is the concept of sabr presented in the Qur'an, and what kinds of patience does it distinguish?'

5.3 Testing the question

Before you commit, test your question against three checks. Can you name the primary sources you will use? Can you name the secondary sources you will consult? Can you imagine what a good answer would look like, and what evidence would count for or against it? If any answer is no, narrow the question or change the sources. A short pilot reading — one afternoon with the key sources — often reveals whether the question is workable. It is far better to narrow a question in the first week than to discover in the last week that it cannot be answered.

Checklist — is my question ready? It is one sentence. It names the subject and the scope. It can be answered from sources I can access. It is narrow enough for my word limit. My supervisor or teacher has seen it and agrees it is workable.

Chapter 6: Structure of an Islamic Research Paper

A research paper is not a list of notes; it is an argument built in order, so that each section prepares the reader for the next. The standard structure below suits almost every paper in Islamic studies. Short papers may combine some sections, but the order and the logic should remain.

6.1 Title and abstract

The title should name the topic and the angle in as few words as possible: 'Sabr in the Qur'an: A Thematic Study' is better than 'Some Thoughts on Patience'. The abstract, usually 150 to 250 words, summarises the question, the method, the main findings and the conclusion, in that order. It does not introduce new evidence and it does not contain citations. A reader should be able to decide from the abstract alone whether the paper is relevant to them.

6.2 Introduction

The introduction states the research question, explains why it matters, gives the necessary background, and outlines how the paper will answer the question. It should end with a short roadmap: 'This paper first examines... then compares... and finally argues...' A good introduction is confident but modest: it promises what the paper can deliver and no more. Avoid opening with sweeping generalisations about Islam or history; begin with your specific question and its context.

6.3 Literature review

The literature review surveys what has already been written on the question. It is organised by theme or by approach, not as a list of summaries. For each important work, note its question, its method, its main conclusion, and its limits — and then say what remains to be done, which is the gap your paper addresses. A literature review that merely praises earlier works is useless; one that shows exactly where the gap

lies gives your paper its justification. In Islamic studies, the review should cover both classical and modern works, and should distinguish between scholarly studies and popular writing.

6.4 Methodology

The methodology section states the method (see Chapter 4), the sources used, and how they were selected and evaluated. If you studied a set of verses, say how they were identified. If you compared schools of law, say which texts you used and why. If you conducted a survey, describe the participants, the questions and the limits of the sample. This section allows the reader to judge whether your conclusions follow from your method — and it allows another researcher to repeat your work.

6.5 Discussion and analysis

This is the body of the paper, usually in two or three sections with clear subheadings. Present the evidence first, then analyse it. In a textual study, work through the passages in a logical order, explaining each one before moving on. In a comparative study, give each view fairly before assessing them. Use quotations sparingly and purposefully: a short quotation of a key phrase is powerful; long blocks of quotation suggest the sources are doing the arguing for you. Every section should end by stating what it has established, so the reader can follow the argument's progress.

6.6 Conclusion and recommendations

The conclusion answers the research question directly, summarises the evidence that supports the answer, acknowledges the limits of the study, and suggests what further research could do. It does not introduce new evidence or new arguments. Recommendations, where appropriate, should follow from the findings: a teaching recommendation, a suggestion for further study, or a practical application. Keep the conclusion short and focused; it is the part of the paper the reader is most likely to remember.

Chapter 7: How to Cite Classical Sources Correctly

Citation is how a researcher shows their work. In Islamic studies it is especially important, because the reader must be able to find the exact verse, the exact hadith and the exact scholarly opinion being discussed. A citation that cannot be checked is little better than no citation at all.

7.1 Citing the Qur'an

Cite the Qur'an by surah name and number and verse number, for example: Qur'an 96:1-5. Give the surah name on first mention so the reader is not left with numbers alone. If you quote a verse in translation, name the translator in a note or in your bibliography, because translations differ. If you discuss the Arabic wording, give the

key Arabic term in transliteration and explain it. Never cite a verse from memory without checking the number: a wrong reference wastes the reader's time and damages your credibility.

7.2 Citing hadith

Cite a hadith by collection, book and number, and, where relevant, by the grading given by the scholars. For example: Sahih al-Bukhari, Book of Revelation, no. 1 — the well-known report beginning 'Actions are but by intentions'. Give enough information for the reader to find the report in a standard edition. If editions number hadith differently, name the edition you used. If a report's authenticity is disputed, say so and name the scholars who questioned it. Do not cite a hadith from a secondary source when you can check the collection itself; and never present a saying as a hadith of the Prophet (peace be upon him) unless you have verified that it is recorded as such.

7.3 Citing scholarly opinions

When you report a scholar's opinion, name the scholar, name the work, and give the volume and page where the opinion appears. Distinguish between what a scholar actually wrote and what later writers say about them. If you rely on a modern summary of a classical work, say so. When scholars disagree, cite each side from its own sources rather than from its opponent's summary. A fair rule is: the reader should be able to verify every substantive claim in your paper without taking your word for it.

7.4 Citation examples

The table below shows the standard forms used in this report. Different universities and journals have their own style guides; follow your institution's guide, but keep the same principles: give enough detail for the reader to find the source, be consistent throughout, and distinguish primary sources from secondary ones.

Source type	Form to use	Example
Qur'an	Qur'an, Surah name (number: verse)	Qur'an, Surah al-'Alaq (96:1-5)
Hadith	Collection, Book, no.	Sahih al-Bukhari, Book of Revelation, no. 1
Hadith (2nd)	Collection, Book, no.	Sahih Muslim, Book of Faith (give no. in your edition)
Tafsir	Author, Title, vol., p.	Author, Book of Tafsir, vol. 1, p. 120 (give full details in bibliography)
Fiqh work	Author, Title, vol., p.	Author, Book of Fiqh, vol. 2, p. 45 (give full details in bibliography)

Modern book	Author, Title (Place: Publisher, Year), p.	Author, Title of the Study (City: Publisher, Year), p. 78
Journal article	Author, 'Title', Journal, vol. (year), pp.	Author, 'Title of the Article', Journal Name, 12 (2024), pp. 34-56

Two final rules apply to every citation. First, cite at the point where the claim is made, not several pages later. Second, keep a full bibliography at the end of the paper with complete publication details for every work cited. A bibliography that lists works you did not actually use is dishonest; a bibliography that omits works you did use is careless.

Worked example — a correctly cited paragraph: 'The Qur'an presents patience as a quality of the believers, commanded in many verses and linked with prayer and with trust in God (see, for example, Qur'an 2:153, in the sense that patience and prayer are enjoined together). The classical commentators explain this pairing as showing that patience is not passive endurance but active perseverance supported by worship. The Prophet's teaching, as recorded in the authentic collections, likewise presents patience as a central virtue, and the commentaries on those reports discuss its kinds and its rewards.' Note how the paragraph gives a verifiable reference, attributes the interpretation to the commentators, and does not invent wording.

Chapter 8: Discussing Differences of Opinion with Respect and Balance

Difference of opinion (ikhtilaf) is a normal and long-established feature of Islamic scholarship. The schools of law differ, theologians differ, and commentators differ over the meaning of verses. A research paper must handle these differences with respect, accuracy and balance — and must avoid the two opposite errors of pretending that no differences exist and of treating differences as a contest to be won.

8.1 Why scholars differ

Scholars differ for understandable reasons. A verse or hadith may admit more than one reading; different reports may appear to point in different directions; a principle may be applied differently to a new case; or scholars may weigh the same evidence differently. Sometimes the difference is one of wording rather than substance, and a careful paper will say so. Explaining why scholars differ is more valuable than merely recording that they do: it turns a list of opinions into an understanding of the question.

8.2 Rules for presenting differing views

- Present each view in its strongest form, using its own evidence, before you assess it.
- Attribute views to named scholars and works, not to whole groups in vague terms such as 'some people say'.
- Do not use dismissive language about any recognised scholarly position, even when you disagree with it.
- Distinguish between differences among scholars and the views of individuals with no scholarly standing; the two are not equivalent.
- If you reach a preference, argue it from evidence and acknowledge the strength of the opposing view.
- Where the evidence is genuinely balanced, say so. An honest 'the evidence does not settle this question' is a respectable conclusion.

8.3 Tone and language

The language of the paper should reflect the respect due to the subject and to the scholars discussed. Refer to the Prophet (peace be upon him) with the customary blessing, and to the Companions and the great scholars with respect. Avoid casual, mocking or sensational language about sacred matters. At the same time, respect does not mean flattery: a paper can disagree with a scholar's conclusion while honouring their learning and sincerity. The test is simple — would the scholar you disagree with recognise their own view in your summary, and would they consider your criticism fair?

This balance matters beyond good manners. Readers trust a paper that treats opposing views fairly, because they can see that the conclusion was reached by weighing evidence rather than by selecting it. A paper that caricatures its opponents may persuade the already convinced, but it will not persuade a careful reader, and it does a disservice to the scholarly tradition it claims to represent.

Chapter 9: Ethics, Respect and Academic Honesty in Islamic Research

Islamic scholarship has always joined knowledge with character. The classical scholars wrote about the etiquette of the student and the teacher, the sincerity of intention, and the responsibility of transmitting knowledge accurately. Modern academic ethics — honesty, fairness, respect for sources and for people — expresses the same values in a contemporary form. This chapter states the standards a research paper must meet.

9.1 Sincerity and intention

Begin with a sincere intention: to learn, to understand, and to benefit others. That intention protects the researcher from the temptations that spoil scholarship — the desire to impress, to win an argument at any cost, or to produce a striking conclusion regardless of the evidence. A researcher who writes for the sake of truth will check a reference once more, will report the inconvenient evidence, and will admit what they do not know.

9.2 Accuracy and honesty

Accuracy is a duty, not a preference. Check every quotation against its source. Check every verse number and hadith number. Do not exaggerate what a source says, do not suppress what it says against your view, and do not present a paraphrase as a quotation. If you cannot verify a claim, do not include it — or include it only as a claim that needs verification, clearly marked as such. A paper that contains one invented quotation loses the reader's trust in everything else it says.

9.3 Plagiarism and proper acknowledgement

Plagiarism — presenting another person's words or ideas as your own — is forbidden in academic work and contrary to the trust on which scholarship rests. It includes copying text without quotation marks, paraphrasing closely without acknowledgement, and using another person's argument or structure without credit. The remedy is simple: whenever an idea, a phrase or an argument comes from another writer, acknowledge it with a citation. Quotation marks, citations and a full bibliography are not formalities; they are how the researcher distinguishes their own contribution from what they have learned from others. When in doubt, cite.

9.4 Respect for sacred texts and for people

Handle the Qur'an and hadith with the reverence they deserve: quote accurately, do not use sacred texts as decoration or as a rhetorical weapon, and do not attribute to them what they do not say. Treat the scholars of the past with respect, even when you disagree with them, and treat living people — teachers, interviewees, fellow students — with courtesy and confidentiality. In fieldwork, protect participants' privacy, obtain their consent, and report their views without distortion. A paper that is technically correct but disrespectful in tone has failed in an important way.

9.5 A researcher's self-check

Before submission, ask: Is every quotation checked? Is every borrowed idea cited? Have I reported the evidence fairly, including the evidence against my view? Have I written about sacred matters and about scholars with respect? Would I be content for my teacher and for the scholars I discuss to read this paper? If any answer is no, revise before submitting.

Chapter 10: A Complete Worked Example: Sabr in the Qur'an

This chapter puts the whole method together in a single worked example. The topic is the concept of sabr (patience, perseverance, steadfastness) in the Qur'an. It is chosen because it is a well-defined Qur'anic theme, because the sources are accessible, and because it shows every stage of the method in a manageable form. A student could adapt this outline directly for a paper of their own, or use it as a model for a different theme.

10.1 The research question

Research question: How is sabr presented in the Qur'an, what kinds of patience does it distinguish, and what rewards and supports does it associate with patience? The question is narrow — one concept, one source, with the classical commentaries as the guide to interpretation — and it can be answered from sources a student can access. The scope is the Qur'anic text itself, studied thematically, with tafsir consulted to explain difficult verses and to record where commentators differ.

10.2 Full outline of the sample paper

1. Title: Sabr in the Qur'an: A Thematic Study. Abstract (about 200 words): question, method, findings, conclusion.

2. Introduction: why sabr matters; the question; the method (thematic textual analysis); the plan of the paper.

3. Literature review: how classical tafsir treats sabr; how modern thematic studies of Qur'anic concepts are organised; the gap — a short, student-level thematic study that groups the verses by kind of patience.

4. Methodology: identification of the relevant verses through a concordance and through the tafsir literature; grouping by theme; use of two or three recognised commentaries for interpretation; limits of the study.

5. Analysis I — The command to be patient: verses that enjoin sabr, and the contexts in which the command appears.

6. Analysis II — Kinds of patience: patience in worship and obedience, patience in hardship and loss, patience in dealing with other people, and patience in resisting wrongdoing.

7. Analysis III — Supports and rewards: the pairing of patience with prayer, the promise of divine help and companionship, and the reward described for the patient.

8. Discussion: what the groupings show; where commentators agree and where they differ; what the theme contributes to a reader's understanding of the Qur'an's moral teaching.

9. Conclusion: a direct answer to the research question, the limits of the study, and

suggestions for further work — for example, a comparison with the presentation of sabr in the hadith literature.

10.3 Model introduction paragraph

Model introduction: 'Patience is one of the most frequently commended qualities in the Qur'an. It is enjoined as a command, praised as a characteristic of the believers, and linked with prayer, with trust in God, and with the promise of reward. Yet the Qur'an does not use the word in a single, undifferentiated sense: patience is called for in worship, in hardship, in dealings with other people, and in resistance to wrongdoing, and each setting gives the quality a different shade of meaning. This paper asks how sabr is presented in the Qur'an, what kinds of patience the text distinguishes, and what supports and rewards it associates with patience. It answers that question by a thematic study of the relevant verses, grouped by context and interpreted with the help of the classical commentaries. The paper first reviews how the commentators have treated the theme, then sets out its method, then analyses the verses in three groups — the command to be patient, the kinds of patience, and the supports and rewards of patience — and finally draws the findings together in a conclusion.'

Notice what this paragraph does: it states the importance of the topic, narrows it to a question, names the method, and gives the reader a roadmap — all without making claims the paper has not yet proved. A student can use this paragraph as a template: replace the topic and the groupings, keep the structure.

10.4 What a good answer would show

A successful paper on this topic would show, with references to specific verses, that sabr is presented as both a command and a virtue; that it appears in distinct contexts which can be grouped meaningfully; that it is consistently paired with supports such as prayer; and that the commentators largely agree on its central meaning while differing on points of detail, such as the precise grouping of its kinds. It would also be honest about its limits: a thematic study of the Qur'an alone cannot settle how sabr was understood in later legal or spiritual literature, and that would be a subject for further research.

Chapter 11: Common Mistakes and a Final Checklist

11.1 Common mistakes

Most weak papers fail in the same few ways, and all of them are avoidable. The first is a question that is too broad, so the paper surveys everything and proves nothing. The second is reliance on secondary sources alone, without reading the primary texts. The third is selective quotation — using only the evidence that supports a pre-chosen conclusion. The fourth is careless citation: wrong verse numbers, hadith quoted without a collection, scholarly opinions attributed vaguely to 'scholars say'.

The fifth is poor structure: sections that do not follow from each other, an introduction that promises more than the paper delivers, and a conclusion that introduces new material. The sixth is disrespectful or partisan language about differences of opinion. The seventh is plagiarism, whether by copying text or by borrowing an argument without acknowledgement. The eighth is a paper submitted without proofreading, so that spelling errors and broken references distract the reader from the argument.

11.2 How to avoid them

Each mistake has a simple remedy. Narrow the question until it can be answered in the available length. Read the primary sources first, and let the secondary sources guide your reading rather than replace it. Actively look for evidence against your first view, and report it. Check every reference before submission. Write an outline before writing the paper, and check the finished paper against the outline. Ask a fellow student or a teacher to read the discussion of differing views and tell you whether it is fair. Run a plagiarism check where your institution provides one, and cite whenever in doubt. Finally, leave time to proofread: a paper finished a day early and read once with fresh eyes is visibly better than one finished at the deadline.

11.3 Final checklist

Use this checklist before submitting any Islamic research paper. Tick each item honestly; if an item is not ticked, fix it before submission.

- My research question is one clear sentence, and the paper answers it.
- My title names the topic and the angle; my abstract summarises question, method, findings and conclusion.
- I have used primary sources (Qur'an and Sunnah) and I have checked every verse and hadith reference.
- I have consulted more than one tafsir or commentary where interpretation matters.
- Differences of opinion are presented fairly, with named scholars and their evidence.
- Every quotation is checked, every borrowed idea is cited, and the bibliography is complete.
- The structure follows the standard order: introduction, literature review, methodology, discussion, conclusion.
- The tone is respectful throughout, including towards views I disagree with.
- I have proofread the whole paper and checked the page numbers, headings and references.
- I have kept a copy of my notes and sources, so I can answer questions about the paper.

Chapter 12: Conclusion

Writing an Islamic research paper is a craft that can be learned, and its principles are simple: ask a clear question, read the primary sources carefully, learn from the scholarship of the past, choose a method suited to the question, structure the argument so the reader can follow it, cite every source so the reader can check it, discuss differences with respect, and write with honesty and humility. None of these steps is difficult on its own; the skill lies in carrying them all out together, and in keeping the intention sincere throughout.

The reward is more than a good grade. A researcher who works in this way gains a deeper understanding of the Qur'an and the Sunnah, a fairer appreciation of the scholars who interpreted them, and the ability to think and write clearly about matters of faith. That understanding, shared honestly with readers, is itself a contribution to knowledge and to the community. The worked example in Chapter 10 shows that a student paper, honestly done on a well-chosen question, can be a genuine piece of research. The checklist in Chapter 11 is the final guard against the errors that most often spoil good work. Used together, the method in this report will serve the reader for every Islamic research paper they write.

Chapter : Suggested Reading

The works below are general, well-known resources for the study of Islamic research methodology and for the classical sources discussed in this report. They are described in general terms so that the reader can find suitable editions in a library; publication details vary by edition and translation, and the reader should consult their institution's library catalogue for the edition available to them.

Classical sources — described generally

- The Qur'an, in a reliable printed Arabic text, with a recognised English translation for reference.
- The two Sahih hadith collections, and the other well-known Sunan collections, in standard editions with their classical commentaries.
- The classical works of tafsir (Qur'anic exegesis), including both the early transmitted commentaries and the later analytical works.
- The authoritative works of fiqh of the recognised schools of law, and works of comparative fiqh (fiqh al-muqaran).
- The classical works on the sciences of hadith (mustalah al-hadith), on the principles of jurisprudence (usul al-fiqh), and on the principles of tafsir (usul al-tafsir).

Works on Islamic research methodology

- Standard introductory works on research methodology in Islamic studies, as recommended by university departments of Islamic studies and Arabic.
- Guides to academic writing and referencing for students in the humanities and religious studies, including the style guide adopted by the reader's own institution.
- Works on the history of Islamic scholarship and on the development of the Islamic sciences, which give the context in which the classical sources were produced.

Reference works

- Concordances of the Qur'an and of hadith, for locating verses and reports by word or theme.
- Biographical dictionaries of scholars and narrators, for checking the standing and dates of the authorities cited.
- Encyclopaedias of Islam and of the Qur'an, for orientation on topics, terms and scholarly debates — to be used as a starting point, not as a substitute for the primary sources.

A final note on using this list: begin with the primary sources and with one reliable methodological guide, and add further reading as your question requires. A short bibliography that you have actually read and used is worth far more than a long one assembled from other people's footnotes.